

buy a gun which has led to a flourishing business in unlicensed weapons. Officially, licences are issued to civilians by the police on the grounds of a perceived threat to personal security or, in a throwback to pre-Independence times, to protect cattle or crops. The police, usually a senior officer, must be convinced that the applicant has a genuine need for the weapon and has no criminal record. In India, like most things requiring official clearance, people with influence and contacts can procure arms licences easily. Once the licence is issued, the applicant can buy the weapon directly from government-run ordnance factories, authorised gun dealers or import it from abroad.

The problem of firearms and their use is becoming greater with every passing year in cities like Mumbai and Delhi which have registered the

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maximum cases of shootings and murders. Though such incidents are rampant in states like Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, those are mostly country-made weapons used by criminals, gangsters and hired killers. Former Director-General of Police (Uttar Pradesh), Prakash Singh says, “Country-made guns have almost become a cottage industry in several parts of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.” According to police records, the reasons given by individuals applying for a licence vary, but most cite threat to life as the reason for needing a weapon which makes it comparatively easy to procure it.

Cities like Hyderabad and Chennai have not remained untouched by this culture of violence. Gunshots rang through the campus of Deccan College of Engineering and Technology, Hyderabad, in April this year when

SHOOT OUT

November 27, 2007

City: Mumbai

Crime: The jilted lover of a 23-year-old model Moushami Das arrived at her apartment and shot dead her mother and uncle and then ended his own life.



Moushami Das; Avinash Patnaik

October 29, 2007

City: Mumbai

Crime: Sibling rivalry ended in bloodshed when hotelier Lalit D'Souza shot and wounded his sister Lorna over a parking spot dispute.

October 29, 2007

City: Delhi

Crime: Delhi-based builder Sulekh Malik's son Varun was allegedly shot dead in the posh Vasant Kunj market area by his friend Moti, who later surrendered in the city court.

September 2007

City: Mumbai

Crime: Hotel owner Mohan Shetty reportedly shot at his younger brother Manohar at their advocate's office over a long festering property dispute.

April 2007

City: Hyderabad

Crime: In a shootout on the campus of Deccan College of Engineering and Technology, Umedullah Khan opened fire on fellow student Mukarram Ali Siddiqui.

October 23, 2006

City: Chennai

Crime: Marwari businessman Menak Chand was allegedly shot dead with a 9mm Chinese pistol by his wife Pramila Devi.

Mohan Shetty (left)



Umedullah Khan, a second-year engineering student opened fire on Mukarram Ali Siddiqui, a rival student leader. In October last year, Chennai was shaken by the murder of a Marwari businessman Menak Chand, who was allegedly shot dead with a 9mm Chinese pistol by his wife Pramila Devi. This alarming escalation of crimes of anger and passion, committed by kith and kin, has left both policemen and psychologists baffled. Bharti says, “Money, property disputes, life-style patterns, pressure to maintain a specific lifestyle without having the means to do so and a false sense of achievement add to frustrations, pushing people to take up arms. There is a yawning gap between real life and people's aspiration. For example, in Das's case, Patnaik's real world was very conservative but he was attracted to her modern ways. Later, he changed his mind and wanted his girlfriend to abandon her glamorous lifestyle in Mumbai and live in his conformist world, hence, the conflict and his resultant extreme behaviour.”

Shetty adds that instances of momentary lapse of reason are increasing. “If social drinking grows then the number of alcoholics will increase. Similarly, if anger on the ground has become high across all sections of society, incidents of violence will also increase.” Considering the fact that many cases registered as non-cognisable offences were later blown up into cognisable cases (like Das's and Lorna's), Bharti says that the cops are now more vigilant. “Now, we watch out for cases of unrequited love, marital spats, property disputes and sibling rivalries. A few years ago such issues were not taken seriously, but today non-cognisable offences are also a cause for concern,” adds Bharti.

While many might argue whether crimes of passion have indeed seen a rise or whether they are just being reported more frequently due to the media boom and the growing penchant for sensationalism, there's no denying that latent traits of violence are finding easy expression in an increasingly stressed urban scenario and gunshots are ringing loud and clear across metros.

with Sandeep Unnithan and Manoj Verma